

eventually finished the first season as the captain. There were thoughts about how it'll go and how I will handle these big players. I did not have answers for these," he concedes during an exclusive interaction with *Sportstar*.

Imagine taking over a team previously led by Rahul Dravid, Anil Kumble and, for what felt like an eternity, Virat Kohli. No pressure.

"It was crucial not to copy any of the predecessors. But there was one thing I was very influenced by from du Plessis: how he spoke to and gave importance to each player. He was confident; his body language conveyed authority on the ground," the Madhya Pradesh batter says.

Another influential figure in the 32-year-old's career is celebrated coach and former international cricketer Chandrakant Pandit. He says the basics of his captaincy stemmed from spending time with the multi-time Ranji Trophy-winning coach.

"Chandu sir taught me how meticulously you can prepare for a cricket game, how deeply you can study it. He has played for 20 years and then coached for another 20. His tactical strength was eye-opening for me," he says.

Engraving your mark

The RCB franchise enjoys the kind of popularity very few other teams have managed in the T20 showpiece. Yet, despite the exponential brand growth, fans were repeatedly left disappointed when it came to success on the pitch.

That 18-year wait finally ended when Patidar lifted the famed trophy after beating a strong Punjab Kings side in Ahmedabad last year.



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"Fans have expectations because it is such a big franchise. There was additional pressure because we hadn't won for 18 years. But in that situation, I kept telling myself that I should focus on what I can control. We have a group of experienced players, and I got a lot of help from them," he says.

"I didn't think much about the future [during the Playoffs]. I knew that if we played the final, it meant we had done a lot of things right throughout the competition. All we had to do was repeat that on the field," he adds.

Creating the perfect storm

There was a marked difference in RCB's team composition ahead of the title-winning season. When the names rolled onto the screen at the end of the mega auction, experts and fans alike believed the squad finally had the perfect mix: batters and bowlers, domestic and overseas players, experience and youth.

For the first time in a while, the franchise appeared to have the resources to go the distance. Patidar, however, believes that was only half the job done.

"First day, everyone was asking what RCB was doing? The team is not picking anybody. When the picking was done on day two, you can see that we knew what kind of roles we needed. But execution is important. If that hadn't gone to plan, then the team wouldn't look that good," he says.

The RCB skipper also underlined the importance of the captain and team management being aligned for a side to truly flourish. He says he learned a great deal about cricket from head coach Andy Flower and director of cricket Mo Bobat. The domestic experience of mentor Dinesh Karthik, spin-bowling coach Malolan Rangarajan and bowling coach Omkar Salvi makes it a well-rounded support staff, he adds.

The Bengaluru-based franchise was among the earliest to tap into the ever-expanding world of data analytics, which Patidar says has now become constant across every level of cricket, from domestic to international.

"It plays an important role irrespective of the format. A bowler should know in and out about the batter, his hitting zones, his

**QUICK
BYTES**

If you can swap a skill with any of your teammates, what would it be, and what's the skill?

Nothing, I wouldn't want to swap anything

Someone who is too energetic for your liking and you'd like to mute?

Jitesh Sharma